



IF I MISSED ANYTHING IN LIFE, IT'S GETTING MARRIED AND HAVING A LITTLE LAD, WHO WOULD HAVE PROBABLY ALSO PLAYED CRICKET

Emotional farewell: Dickie Bird wipes a tear as MCC and England players applaud him onto the Lord's turf for his final Test as umpire. GETTY IMAGES



Quiet authority: Umpire Dickie Bird keeps a close eye as Madan Lal steams in and Jeffrey Dujon looks on during the 1983 World Cup final at Lord's.

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his youth, Bird holds both sports close to his heart. But as he puts it, he is "married to cricket."

In his playing days, Bird shared a dressing room with Geoffrey Boycott at the Barnsley Cricket Club before signing a professional contract with Yorkshire at 19, earning a retainer of up to £650. In the off-season, he worked as a travelling salesman for a sports goods store.

Those memories cheer him up. But in more recent years, the silence at home has grown heavier. Many of his old friends have passed on.

"Time flies. I am beginning to feel my age now," he says.

"It's not easy to live on your own at this age, but I carry on the best I can. I never married, and got myself married to cricket. But if I missed anything in life is getting married and having a little lad, who would have probably also played cricket," he says in a jest.

That, he says, would have been tremendous, "but it wasn't to be."

He played 93 matches as a right-handed batter for Yorkshire and Leicestershire, but his true renown came from umpiring. Bird officiated in 66 Tests and 69 ODIs before retiring in 1996, during India's Test at Lord's, a match that marked the debuts of Sourav Ganguly and Rahul Dravid.

Beyond the field, he also served as president of Yorkshire County Cricket Club, using over £125,000 of his savings to build a new dressing room and gallery at Headingley.

"The old dressing room was in a poor shape, and teams weren't